
He's Shy. He's Awkward. He's an Olympic Figure Skating Champion.

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Throughout these Winter Olympics, the surest bet in Milan was that American figure skater Ilia Malinin, the vaunted “Quad God,” [would dominate the men's individual figure-skating contest](#) and bring home Olympic gold. But when Malinin took the ice on Friday—and there's no other way to say this—he choked. And instead of the Olympic coronation we had all banked on, the figure-skating gold went to... some 21-year-old from Kazakhstan who still has braces on his teeth?

It's safe to say that *Mikhail Shaidorov is the 2026 Olympic gold medalist* is a sentence that nobody expected to hear this February. Probably not even Mikhail Shaidorov! After all, Malinin's skill with the death-defying quadruple axel—he is the only skater to ever land one in competition—has upended the sport and arguably remade it in his own image. While Shaidorov is a masterful technician on the ice, he doesn't have a quad axel in his arsenal, and, as [Chris Schleicher wrote in Slate](#), he “has a long way to go with his presentation.” Figure-skating experts have long thought that Shaidorov's time was coming—but, as Schleicher noted, that time was supposed to come in 2030, not in 2026.

The fact that his moment came earlier than anyone expected is, in a lot of ways, a better story than the one we all were expecting to write. Most of the fictional sports stories I read as a kid revolved around the notion that, in any given competition, an underdog can rise to the moment. In real life, things rarely work out that way. For every story I've ever written about a triumphant Olympic underdog—USA's Team Shuster [winning curling gold](#) in 2018 is my favorite example—there are hundreds where the athletes everyone expected to win *did* win, handily. Shaidorov's gold medal was Kazakhstan's second-ever Winter Olympic gold. The United States won two gold medals just this Wednesday.

“Best athlete from richest country does it again” is less a story than a fact of life. In Olympic competition, the longitudinal triumph of the overdog is largely a matter of national inequities. Team USA isn't overloaded with medal contenders because “we grow ‘em better over here.” Even though American Olympians get no direct state support during their training, the coaching and training resources top athletes can draw on in the U.S. are nevertheless unparalleled—not to mention the inherent advantage that comes from living in a wealthy country with plenty of qualified doctors, a stable education system, and good roads. There's a reason why so many people want to come here (or at least why so many people *used to* want to come here).

Shaidorov is from Almaty, Kazakhstan, which is surely a very nice place to call home but no one's idea of a figure skating mecca. Over the course of his still young career, Shaidorov has done the best he can with what he has. Like Malinin, he was born into a figure-skating family—his father, Stanislav Shaidorov, was a [six-time](#) Kazakh national champion—and at a young age he started skating at the best facility Almaty had to offer: the rink at a local shopping mall.

When Shaidorov outgrew the mall, he had to leave the country. He found a suitable facility in Sochi, Russia, where he trained with 1994 Olympic gold medalist Alexei Urmanov. [In a 2025 interview](#), Shaidorov spoke wearily of having “to travel for visas and search for ice because I still don't have suitable training conditions in my hometown of Almaty to train properly.” Olympic skaters from marquee nations benefit from armies of specialists who help them maximize nutrition, recuperation, and performance. According to Shaidorov, the Kazakh national figure-skating team doesn't even have its own doctor.

"I don't have the same conditions as other top athletes from Japan, the U.S., South Korea, and so on," Shaidorov said [in that same 2025 interview](#). "This sport is very political, and if you're not part of a strong federation, you receive different treatment compared to athletes from top countries."

The only other Kazakh Winter Olympic figure-skating medalist was Denis Ten, also from Almaty, who took bronze in Sochi in 2014. Ten was tragically [stabbed to death by car thieves](#) four years later.

As a boy growing up in a skating family, Shaidorov was inspired by Ten's example. (Ten trained at one point with Shaidorov's father.) "Many journalists from South Korea and China have told me that Denis always dreamed of seeing skaters emerge who could continue to represent Kazakhstan at a high level," he said [in another 2025 interview](#). "I hope he would be proud of what I'm doing now."

When Shaidorov gave that interview, he had just recently won the [men's singles competition](#) at the 2025 Four Continents Championships in South Korea. A month later, he skated at the World Figure Skating Championships in Boston, where he took the silver medal in the men's singles competition. The gold medalist? Malinin, who dazzled the crowd with a free skate that featured six quads, including a quad axel—and who beat Shaidorov by a whopping 31.09 points.

On Friday in Milan, everyone expected history to repeat itself, at least in terms of Malinin's performance. As for Shaidorov, NBC's Terry Gannon summed it up when the Kazakh skater got ready for his moment in the spotlight. "The man taking the ice certainly does have the talent, and he's had big moments," Gannon said as Shaidorov began his free skate. "Can he bring it here to Olympic ice?"

It's the sort of thing an announcer says when he suspects the answer is *no*. As Shaidorov continued his free skate, it was clear the NBC booth did not take his medal ambitions all that seriously. "The technical [elements] will get you those points, but it's the *polish*, the performance, that will get you those medals," said Tara Lipinski. "So he's just planting seeds right now for his campaign for the next Olympic cycle."

But Shaidorov kept racking up those technical points—and by the time he collapsed to the ice, exhausted and triumphant, at the end of his free skate, the booth had changed its tune. "Guys, you never know, in terms of the podium. He's less than 10 points out of third place," said an excited Gannon.

"He skated lights out there," said Lipinski. "I don't know, guys. ... That's going to be interesting."

When his cumulative score vaulted him into first place, Shaidorov, clutching a stuffed panda, jumped up and thrust his arms in the air triumphantly. Then, as the moment hit him, he sank back into his seat and started crying. All he could do was wait for Malinin—and when, 30 minutes later, the American skater's blunderous program had secured Shaidorov the gold, the Kazakh skater covered his face with his hands as he rose to meet his American rival in a long embrace.

Malinin quickly made his exit, leaving Shaidorov alone, and to my eye somewhat shell-shocked. "He told me that the best two words to describe him are *awkward* and *shy*," NBC's Johnny Weir had said earlier. Shaidorov had been expected to skate well, plant those seeds for 2030, and hopefully be invited to perform his fan-favorite routine at the Olympic figure skating exhibition gala next weekend.

“At the beginning of 2024, I decided I wanted to skate in a panda costume,” [Shaidorov said last year](#). “I wanted to show some parallels with *Kung Fu Panda* because, like the character, I can be clumsy too. The message of the routine is that even if you’re clumsy, you can still become a Dragon Warrior. Nothing is impossible.”

After Friday’s improbable victory, who among us would disagree?

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